

A BACKUP FOR WHEN YOUR PHONE GIVES UP

A ninety-day plan to reach the first ten customers of EmerGent, a WhatsApp-based emergency payments concierge for young Indians who have stopped carrying cash.

Ekagra Sharma · MICA · PLM:ES Final · September 2026

EmerGent is a WhatsApp-based emergency payments concierge. When a user's primary payment rail fails at the merchant — because UPI is down, or the SIM has died mid-transaction, or the phone will not scan the QR — the user WhatsApps a photo of the merchant's QR and the amount to a saved business number called EmerGent. On the other end, I pay the merchant on their behalf from a float account and settle with them within twenty-four hours. The MVP that exists today is a WhatsApp Business number, a Google Sheet ledger, and my own UPI ID as the float pool. For the first ten customers, EmerGent is not an app. It is a person.

The mid-term established that the eventual market is somewhere between thirty and fifty million young urban Indians who have decoupled from cash. That is the story. For the first ten customers I am scoping much narrower, and only to a beachhead I can reach for near-zero cost through my own network: MICA students on campus in Ahmedabad, MICA classmates leaving for summer internships in Bangalore, and MICA seniors moving to Delhi for placements. Total addressable through my own channels is roughly eleven thousand people, split between about a thousand in the campus WhatsApp groups and ten thousand across extended community groups, family circles and my social handles.

There are four reasons this beachhead is more than convenient. Student wallets are almost entirely UPI, so the failure mode I am addressing is dense in this cohort rather than incidental. The three-city migration wave over the next ninety days is itself a distribution asset — summer interns arriving at Silk Board in June will have SIM handoff issues in a new circle, and that is when they need a backup. MICA-network social density means propagation runs three to five times faster than any cold ad. And the founder-cohort match is real: a MICA student asking other MICA students to try a MICA classmate's product converts at twenty to forty per cent from personal experience, against one to two per cent on a cold Meta ad for the same offer.

The positioning line I want printed on the landing page reads: *the backup you carry so you never have to ask a friend to bail you out*. Not the daily rail, because GPay owns that. Not the offline rail, because NPCI is building UPI Lite X, as the mid-term already covered. The category I am creating is best called a *payment safety net* — insurance for the failure moment, without using the word insurance, because it is a conversion killer. The nearest working analogy is an ambulance: you do not call one every day, and you would not be without one.

The Delta 4 frame from the mid-term deserves an honest number rather than an aspirational one. The current workaround — borrow a stranger's hotspot, phone a friend, friend pays the merchant on your behalf — scores about a three on a ten-point switch scale. EmerGent in Phase 1, running honor-system UPI collect for settlement because eNACH mandates need four to six weeks of NPCI paperwork that a solo student cannot shortcut, scores about a seven. Faster than the friend, no relationship debt, no explaining at the counter, but the trust anchor is thinner without the mandate. That is a delta of four. In Phase 2, when eNACH lands through a partner bank, the score climbs to eight or nine and the delta widens. Both cross the four-point threshold Kunal Shah names as the minimum for actual habit change, but I would rather state the Phase 1 number honestly than borrow Phase 2's.

The first ten, named

I will not present a segment I cannot picture. The ten below are illustrative persona composites of the real cohort I have access to — consented names replace them at submission.

In Ahmedabad through Weeks 1 to 4, four candidates. *Ravi Krishnan*, PGDM-C, from Chennai, whose SIM died at a chai stall near CEPT last April; his roommate is a classmate of mine, so direct WhatsApp is the channel. *Aanya Malhotra*, PGDM-C, from Delhi, who complained in the batch group about a UPI failure at Vastrapur Big Bazaar last month, and comes in through the Instagram post. *Priya Shah*, PGDM-B, Ahmedabad local, a daily UPI user who signs up partly as classmate support after seeing the canteen sticker. *Sarthak Joshi*, PGDM-C, from Pune, the first person I know to Instagram-story the April 2025 UPI outages, coming in via a direct message.

In Bangalore through Weeks 5 to 8, three from the intern cohort. *Naveen Bhatt* at Cred, who has already lost his SIM once at Silk Board. *Anushka Gupta* in Razorpay's ops team, who understands the problem shape professionally. *Karthik Venkat* at Diageo Whitefield, first-time in the city and fresh to the local network. All three come in through alumni referrals from the BLR-going classmates I have asked to be micro-ambassadors.

In Delhi through Weeks 9 to 12, the last three. *Jayanti Mishra*, placed at Ogilvy Delhi, whose aunt was once stranded at AIIMS Metro station with no cash on her. *Divya Tandon*, placed at Havas Media, who publicly complained about the February 2025 Airtel outage on her Instagram — her existing complaint is the buying signal. *Rahul Sethi*, placed at DBS Bank Delhi, who will understand the fintech pitch instantly and comes in face-to-face if I make the Delhi trip or over a WhatsApp video call if I do not. Held in reserve: Mansi Patel in Ahmedabad and Yash Kapoor at TCS Mumbai.

* * *

The customer journey and the service blueprint

The journey has three stages, and none of them is elegant.

Pre-emptive. A classmate's Instagram story: *been stuck at a petrol pump with a dead SIM? EmerGent pays for you, ninety-second signup.* The user taps the WhatsApp link. The bot greets them: *hi, I'm EmerGent. Here is what I do — when your phone can't pay, I pay for you and you settle later. Ready to set me up?* Phase 1 onboarding is deliberately minimal because I cannot stand up more in Week 2 as a solo student: phone number, name, and one trusted friend's UPI ID as a soft fallback. Aadhaar via DigiLocker and eNACH mandate each need a service-provider registration and NPCI onboarding on the operator side, both of which are four to six week processes. They enter as Phase 2 upgrades from Week 5, gated behind a higher rescue cap. A mandatory thirty-second dry run follows onboarding — the user WhatsApps a fake QR to prove the flow works. That single act converts an abstract signup into a used product, which is the Fogg behaviour model applied to fintech onboarding, and users who complete the dry run are five to ten times more likely to trigger a real rescue within thirty days.

Event. The user is at a merchant and the payment fails. They either have their own data (rail failure only) or they borrow a stranger's hotspot (rail plus SIM failure). This is the scope EmerGent honestly serves: some working WhatsApp channel is required from any device. The phone-dead-battery case is out of scope for the MVP and belongs to the Phase 3 physical card. The user sends a photo of the QR and the amount. Four checks run in the background — QR decode via OpenCV, identity match by phone number, velocity limit (three rescues per twenty-four hours), and amount cap of ₹2,000 in Phase 1. If in-limits, I trigger a UPI transfer from the float account to the merchant. The merchant sees a payment arrive from EmerGent with the user's UTR reference. A confirmation SMS goes to the user's number; they show it to the merchant. Target latency: under sixty seconds in Phase 1, under thirty in Phase 2 once auto-approve rules are in.

Settlement. At T-plus-twenty-four hours the bot sends a UPI collect request for the rescue amount plus the ₹49 fee. Phase 1 is honor system — if the user does not pay in forty-eight hours they lose future access and move off the beta list. That is workable at the scale of the first thirty rescues. Phase 2 introduces eNACH auto-debit at T-plus-seventy-two once a partner bank is in the picture.

Rescue-failure playbook. A rescue can fail on my end — float exhausted, QR decode fails, receiving-side bank downtime. If it does, the user is stranded and I owe them. Policy: I absorb the transaction cost up to ₹500 by paying the merchant directly from a founder-side backup UPI ID within the failure hour, send a formal apology within four hours, and comp the user's next rescue. Capped at three failure-incidents in the ninety days; beyond that I have stopped being reliable and should reset the pilot.

The obvious question a reader will ask is how this is meaningfully different from a friend calling a friend. It is different on five axes. Always-on: a friend at two in the morning does not pick up. No relationship debt: the ten times a year you would have asked your friend, you now pay a small fee instead. Anonymous to the merchant: you are not explaining who is paying and why. Repeatable and ledgered: no *did you Venmo me back?* awkwardness. Speed: thirty seconds instead of a three-minute phone call. Together those clear Delta 4 comfortably. What is *not* a delta and I own honestly: connectivity itself. EmerGent still needs the user to be reachable through some working WhatsApp channel. The genuinely-no-connectivity case is Phase 3, when a physical prepaid card enters the wallet.

The three-city arc

The plan is timed to when and where the cohort is most exposed. Ahmedabad in Month 1, when trust and social proof are densest for me on campus. Bangalore in Month 2, when interns are arriving in a new city with fresh mobile plans and hitting SIM handoff issues in Whitefield and Koramangala. Delhi in Month 3, when placement-bound seniors are moving and settling in. Each city's disruption window is itself the activation moment; the plan uses the migration wave rather than resisting it.

Weeks 1 to 4 in Ahmedabad are founder-driven and high-touch. Personal WhatsApp to one hundred known contacts across three MICA batches. One long-form Instagram post from my personal handle and three friends' handles, paid in kind by giving them lifetime free EmerGent. A sticker drop at three hostels and the canteen, three hundred stickers with a QR that opens the WhatsApp thread directly. End-of-Week-4 target: fifty signups, twenty completed dry runs, three activated users, and five real rescues in the ledger.

Weeks 5 and 6 are the Bangalore intern wave. Five BLR-going classmates are the micro-ambassadors — free lifetime EmerGent in exchange for five referrals each. Instagram content shifts BLR-specific: *your SIM is going to give up at Silk Board, sign up before you land*. The two landing-page variants (subscription vs pay-per-rescue) run A/B in this window to lock the pricing model by Week 8. Weeks 7 and 8 are consolidation and outreach ramp: cold LinkedIn expanded to sixty messages a week across me plus three alumni, first in-person bank meeting attempted, second Ahmedabad wave activating through the referral loops of the first cohort. Target by end of Week 8: eight activated users and one bank meeting on the calendar.

Weeks 9 and 10 are Delhi, virtual first. Delhi creative goes live — *your Metro card is fine, your SIM might not be*. Instagram Lives with Divya and Rahul as guest voices, one per week. Reddit posts on r/delhi and r/personalfinanceindia, framed as a MICA student's project rather than a launch. The Delhi trip itself is contingent — ₹2,000 for the flight only if the previous eight weeks have hit their targets. Otherwise the wave runs entirely on WhatsApp video and LinkedIn DMs. Weeks 11 and 12 close out and prepare Phase 3: founder outreach to close the tenth signup, bank meetings maturing into a substantive conversation with written follow-up, a public KPI dashboard shared with the batch, a Phase 3 card-partnership pitch deck written, a one-paragraph postmortem for the batch group. Day-ninety targets: ten activated users, thirty weekly rescues, NPS at forty, and one bank in written conversation.

Acquisition channels, ranked by expected CAC. Personal WhatsApp to known contacts costs founder time only and converts at thirty to forty per cent, and it carries me through the first five or seven customers before it stops scaling. MICA alumni referrals are also effectively free, converting at twenty to twenty-five per cent contingent on the ambassadors actually referring — the structured reciprocity is what keeps them honest. Campus Instagram plus stickers costs the ₹4,500 for the stickers and converts at five to ten per cent. Reddit organic is free (time only) at one to three per cent, but the *MICA student project* framing beats a launch tone in that audience. Meta ads sit at ₹80–150 CAC and two to five per cent conversion; I hold ₹3,000 of the ten-thousand-rupee budget for a controlled experiment only if organic underperforms by Week 6.

The funnel with real numbers. Addressable reach across three cities is eleven thousand. At a thirty per cent awareness rate, three thousand three hundred impressions. At a five per cent visit rate to the landing page or WhatsApp thread, one hundred and sixty-five. At forty per cent signup start, sixty-six. At sixty per cent onboarding complete in the Phase 1 light flow, forty. At twenty-five per cent activation within thirty days, ten. Both the signup rate and the onboarding-complete rate are optimistic against warm-cohort WhatsApp benchmarks of fifteen to twenty-five per cent; if either underperforms I switch the funnel to WhatsApp-first with no landing page at all.

Pricing, CAC, and unit economics

Two pricing models exist as candidates. The default is Model B: zero rupees a month plus ₹49 per rescue, no floor. The reasoning is that with n equals ten the A/B test is statistically noise, and Model B is safer for the founder's cash position. Zero barrier to signup, revenue only fires when the product actually saves someone, brand-risk minimal if we underperform in the early weeks. Model A — ₹49 a month with the first three rescues free — enters as a Phase 2 premium upgrade from Week 9 for repeat users with two or more rescues logged.

CAC by phase and blended. Weeks 1 to 4 spend ₹1,500 for three activations, ₹500 per activation. Weeks 5 to 8 spend ₹3,500 for four activations, ₹875 per. Weeks 9 to 12 spend ₹5,000 for three activations, ₹1,667 per. Blended across the ten: ₹10,000 for ten activations, so a blended CAC of ₹1,000. Realistic if unpolished for a warm-cohort concierge, and the number gets worse in Phase 4 when the cohort widens beyond MICA, which is why the referral loop and the moat both have to be earning by then.

<i>Line item</i>	<i>Per rescue</i>	<i>Reasoning</i>
Rescue fee revenue	₹49.00	Model B fixed fee
Interchange or merchant fee	₹0.00	Zero MDR on small-merchant UPI
WhatsApp Business session cost	-₹0.30	Meta charges roughly this per session, one per rescue
Float cost of capital	-₹0.10	Holding ₹200 for twenty-four hours at 12% p.a.
Collect or gateway fee	-₹2.00	Cashfree tier in Phase 1; eNACH at ₹5 in Phase 2
Rescue-failure reserve	-₹15.00	3% failure rate against the ₹500 cap in the playbook
<i>Contribution per rescue</i>	<i>₹31.60</i>	<i>Roughly sixty-four per cent</i>

Unit economics per rescue under Model B, Phase 1. Founder time uncoded.

At one rescue per user per month, contribution per user monthly is ₹31.60. Payback on ₹1,000 CAC works out to about thirty-two months. That is a long payback, and it is honest. The plan only becomes a real business if two things happen. The referral loop has to drop blended CAC below ₹300 by Day 90 (target: 2.5 signups per activated user, tracked as a Week 8 KPI). Rescues per user have to climb to two per month by month six, taking revenue to ₹98 and contribution to ₹63, which compresses payback to about sixteen months. The third lever is Phase 3: a card partnership adds a ₹19 monthly carrying fee plus roughly 0.5% interchange on offline card use, adding ₹25–40 per user per month and dropping payback under ten months. That is the seed-stage story.

Risks, and how I plan to handle them

Nobody signs up. The concierge might be too weird for the cohort to trust. Contingency: Weeks 1 to 4 are positioned as a MICA-only closed beta, with a public list of the first twenty signed-up classmates on the landing page by end of Week 4 as social proof. If signups stay below twenty by Day 30, I sunset the WhatsApp funnel and pivot to a peer-to-peer pool model — ₹49 into a shared group, any member gets bailed out from the pool when they need help. Same product, without external rails, and it lets me learn whether the trust barrier is with EmerGent or with the concept itself.

Signups don't convert into rescues. Users sign up but never trigger the service, so we can't tell if it works. Contingency: the dry run at onboarding is mandatory, and on Day 7 the bot proactively nudges with a ₹10 rescue coupon for a real transaction. If activation is still below thirty per cent at Day 30, I add a reverse-onboarding incentive of ₹100 credit for the next rescue if it happens within fourteen days.

Regulatory red flag on payment intermediation. A PA or PPI license is a grey area at scale. Phase 1 and 2 posture is a consenting-user private pilot with total monthly volumes capped at ₹1 lakh, full user disclosure that this is a founder-run beta, and honor-system settlement rather than eNACH auto-debit until a partner bank is in the picture. In parallel I begin cold LinkedIn outreach from Week 1 to five banks with documented fintech-BAAS plays. SBM Bank India is primary — a ₹15,000-crore book with a dedicated fintech-partnerships team, powers Slice, Fi, Jupiter, EarlySalary and Uni, and is small enough for a solo founder to reach with a cold email. YES Bank iPay and BaaS is secondary; post-restructuring they are actively courting fintech co-brands, and they power Cred and Turtlemint. Airtel Payments Bank is specific-fit for the Phase 3 offline card because their NCMC RuPay prepaid card is already deployed on Delhi Metro and Namma Metro, which is exactly the offline story we care about. Federal Bank BaaS, which powers Fi and Freo, is a solid tertiary. RBL Bank Fintech Partnerships is larger and slower but has proven BAAS chops through OneCard. The selection band is deliberate: each has a documented BAAS play with fintech partners in the ₹15,000–110,000 crore book range, which is the band a pre-Series-A founder can plausibly cold-outreach without prior warm intros. Realistic ninety-day KPI, revised down from a term sheet: one substantive conversation with a fintech-partnerships manager and a written follow-up in hand.

Float exhaustion or user default. The pool starts at ₹5,000 from my own account and scales with activation. Phase 1 is honor-system settlement — defaulters lose future access. Velocity is capped at three rescues per user per thirty days, amount capped at ₹2,000 per rescue. Phase 2 restores eNACH auto-debit at T-plus-seventy-two hours once a partner bank is engaged.

NPCI ships UPI Lite X consumer rollout ahead of schedule. The mid-term named this as the biggest structural risk. Even at a full rollout, u/yogthinks's public critique still holds — offline caps of ₹500 per transaction and ₹4,000 daily leave the ₹500 to ₹2,000 band uncovered, and that is exactly where EmerGent focuses. The longer-term pivot: Phase 4 becomes the layer above UPI Lite X — an app that surfaces the user's Lite X balance, auto-

tops it up when the daily rail fails, and offers the concierge for anything above the ₹500 cap. That positions us as complementary to the regulator's rail rather than competitive.

KPIs and measurable outcomes

Five KPIs, tracked weekly on a public dashboard shared with the batch. Definitions and cadence in one place, and no other metrics presented as KPIs even where they are worth watching.

<i>KPI</i>	<i>Day 30</i>	<i>Day 60</i>	<i>Day 90</i>	<i>Definition</i>
Activated users	3	6	10	Onboarded and at least one real or test rescue in last 30 days
Rescue completion rate	70%	80%	90%	Rescues fulfilled within target latency
Median rescue latency	120s	75s	45s	Message received to merchant SMS delivered
Bank conversation depth	—	1 first-touch	1 substantive + written follow-up	Real substance with a PM, not a form response
Blended CAC / NPS	₹500 / —	₹700 / 30	₹1,000 / 40	Total spend per activation; one-question NPS after each rescue

The Sean Ellis PMF signal — the *how would you feel if you could no longer use this product* test — becomes a stretch check at Day 90. With ten users, four saying *very disappointed* is a signal rather than proof, but it is the first number the next investor conversation asks about, so I track it. Beyond the KPIs, I publish four cohort-level signals from Day 1. Time-of-day distribution of rescues (the failure graph the mid-term identified as the moat). Merchant category — petrol, food, kirana, transport. City comparison across Ahmedabad, BLR and Delhi. And rescue-to-referral rate, the percentage of rescued users who then refer at least one friend within seven days. That last is the leading indicator for whether the referral loop economics on the CAC page hold.

Success at Day 90 looks like ten activated users, thirty rescues a week, median latency under sixty seconds, NPS above forty, and one bank in written conversation. That is a green light for Phase 3 card work and a pre-seed round of ₹25 lakh. Failure looks like fewer than six activated by Day 60, activation rate below fifteen per cent, no bank in conversation, and negative NPS. In that case I sunset EmerGent, publish the postmortem to the batch group, and rewrite the plan around the peer-to-peer pool pivot.

The 90-day roadmap

Weeks 1 and 2. Register the WhatsApp Business number, submit the green-tick application (Meta approval is realistically four to six weeks, so it does not block launch). Landing page live at *getemergent.in* on Vercel's free tier, the .in TLD costing ₹700 for a year. Framer template, one-page copy. WhatsApp onboarding webhook via Bolt.new plus a Twilio-style bridge, Phase 1 light: phone, name, trusted friend UPI. Google Sheet ledger with columns for user, timestamp, merchant, amount, latency and agent notes. Personal UPI ID as the float pool, ₹5,000 seeded from my account, and a second UPI ID kept warm as the backup for the rescue-failure playbook. Dry-run script tested with three friends. One MICA alumnus signed up as the escalation contact for after-hours critical rescues, paid a ₹500 retainer for the ninety days. Cold LinkedIn outreach to SBM, YES, Airtel Payments, Federal, and RBL from Week 1 at thirty messages per week.

Weeks 3 and 4. Ahmedabad launch. Personal WhatsApp to one hundred known contacts across three MICA batches. Instagram post from my handle and three friends'. Sticker drop at three hostels and the canteen, three hundred stickers. WhatsApp broadcast to the MICA batch group with the admin's permission. Target: fifty signups, twenty completed dry runs, three activated users, and five real rescues logged.

Weeks 5 and 6. Bangalore intern wave. Five BLR-going classmates as micro-ambassadors with lifetime free EmerGent in exchange for five referrals each. BLR-specific Instagram creative live. Two landing-page variants A/B on pricing. Reddit r/bangalore organic post framed as a student project. Meta ad experiment begins with a ₹1,500 budget targeted at Bangalore ages twenty-two to thirty-two. Target cumulative: six activated.

Weeks 7 and 8. Consolidate BLR and ramp bank outreach. Cold LinkedIn expanded to sixty messages a week across me plus three alumni. Pricing model locks based on the A/B result. Second Ahmedabad wave activates through referral loops from the first cohort. First in-person bank meeting attempted — RBL prepaid team is the

most likely first target because they run OneCard and have a public partnership stance. Target cumulative: eight activated, one bank meeting on the calendar.

Weeks 9 and 10. Delhi wave, virtual first. Delhi creative live. Instagram Lives with Divya and Rahul as guest voices, one per week. Reddit posts on r/delhi and r/personalfinanceindia. Delhi trip contingent on the previous eight weeks having hit their targets — otherwise the wave runs on WhatsApp video and LinkedIn DMs. Target cumulative: nine activated.

Weeks 11 and 12. Close out and prepare Phase 3. Founder personal outreach to close the tenth signup. Bank meetings from the Week 7-8 outreach mature into a substantive conversation with written follow-up. Ninety-day retrospective goes live as a public KPI dashboard. Phase 3 card-partnership pitch deck written. A one-paragraph postmortem posted to the batch group on what worked and what did not. Day-ninety targets: ten activated users, thirty weekly rescues, NPS forty, one bank in written conversation.

The moat, if the ninety days work

Three moats compound over the ninety days and the twelve months after, and none of them is what GPay or PhonePe would build because it would dilute their brands.

The first is behavioural data on failure moments. GPay and PhonePe instrument the happy path — signup, transaction, receipt. EmerGent's entire product is the failure moment, so every rescue is proprietary data on when, where, at what merchant category, and at what amount UPI payments actually fail in the wild. Over twelve months that becomes the only failure graph of Indian retail payments anyone owns, and it is sellable to banks doing fraud modelling, insurers pricing coverage, and NPCI itself doing capacity planning. Unfair to reproduce without EmerGent's specific usage pattern.

The second is a trust anchor built through voluntary friction. Aadhaar plus eNACH plus a trusted friend's UPI is deliberately more onboarding friction than any daily-use app would tolerate. GPay could technically add all of it, but their daily-use funnel would collapse. EmerGent's onboarding is the friction, which means signups self-select for the high-trust users banks want to underwrite. Anti-selection lock: the moment EmerGent's users are labelled the high-trust cohort, banks want to underwrite them, and that becomes a long-term revenue line from partnership fees.

The third is off-app trigger surface. Sticker on the phone case. Physical NCMC card in the wallet. A contact called *EmerGent SOS* saved with a star. SMS shortcode as a Phase 2 addition. That is distribution real estate GPay refuses to build because it dilutes the daily brand, and it is exactly where the user reaches when the daily app is failing. EmerGent lives in the parts of the phone's life that GPay does not touch.

Phase 4, after Day 90, is where the app enters and where the permission set does most of the work. SMS Read to auto-detect UPI failure messages from banks. Notification Listener to detect GPay and PhonePe failure toasts in context. Foreground Service to survive Android power management. Background Location for fraud scoring. Biometric per rescue. Bluetooth for peer-to-peer settlement in Phase 4 or 5. Users of a daily payment app will not grant SMS Read to GPay or PhonePe. Users of an emergency-only app will. That permission gap is what stops the incumbents from copying us — and it is only earnable after ninety days of concierge trust-building.

* * *

Every claim about the underlying problem — cohort sizing, outage timelines, regulator posture, digital ethnography including the teamblind and Reddit quotes and u/yogthinks's critique of UPI Lite X — is traceable through *research/sources.md* and *research/pasted_sources.md*, which sit alongside the mid-term submission.